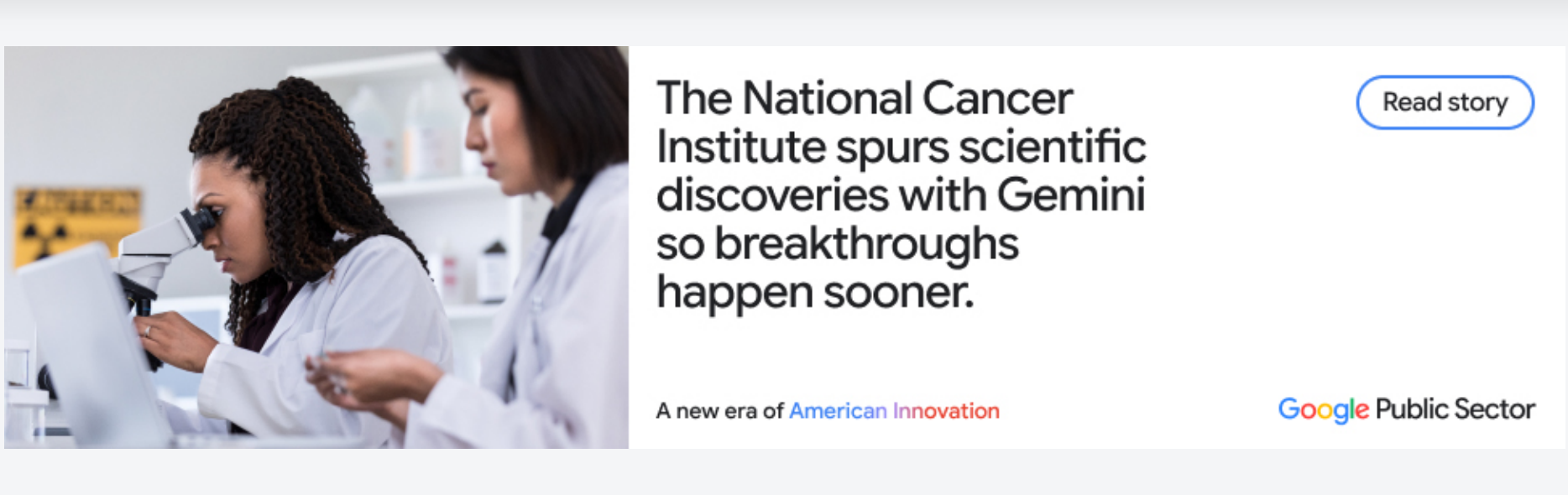
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SEP 2026

House Oversight chair **still wants attorney general** to testify on handling of the Epstein files

Todd Blanche said he would come in for a transcribed interview once he was confirmed, which happened in August.

CHRIS MARQUETTE
09/03/2026, 12:18PM ET

House Oversight Chair James Comer says he still wants Attorney General Todd Blanche to testify as part of the panel's Jeffrey Epstein investigation, suggesting that could happen as soon as this month.

"I've asked Blanche numerous times to come in. He indicated to me that he would after he got confirmed, and he's been confirmed. And I again sent the note out to Blanche," the Kentucky Republican told reporters Thursday.

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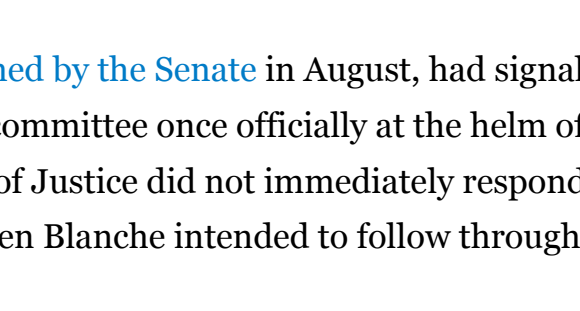
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Comer's staff also recently reiterated the committee chair's request that Blanche testify, according to one person granted anonymity to share details of the private outreach.

But Comer also sought to temper expectations now that House GOP leaders have announced the chamber will only be in session one more week in September before recessing until after the November elections.

While the committee has convened interviews and depositions in the past as part of its Epstein probe, it could be logistically more difficult to get members back to Washington who might be tied up with campaigning.

"I think everybody was waiting to see what the House calendar was," Comer said of the delay in setting a date with Blanche.

Blanche, who was confirmed by the Senate in August, had signaled to Comer that he would appear before the committee once officially at the helm of the Department of Justice. The Department of Justice did not immediately respond to a request for comment about if and when Blanche intended to follow through on that commitment.

The Oversight panel wants to hear more about Blanche's handling of the release of the Epstein files when he was still serving as deputy attorney general. Pam Bondi, who preceded Blanche in the top DOJ job, told the Committee in her transcribed interview that Blanche was essentially responsible for the haphazard rollout of the materials, including botched redactions.

"Blanche supervised [the] entire process" to fulfill the requirements of the law Congress passed past year compelling the files' release, Bondi said at the time.

Comer said he is also eager for Blanche to answer questions about pertinent documents that are still outstanding and why they have yet to be produced.

Lead Art: Acting Attorney General Todd Blanche arrives for a congressional tribute to the late Sen. Lindsey Graham in the U.S. Capitol Rotunda on July 28, 2026. | Francis Chung/POLITICO

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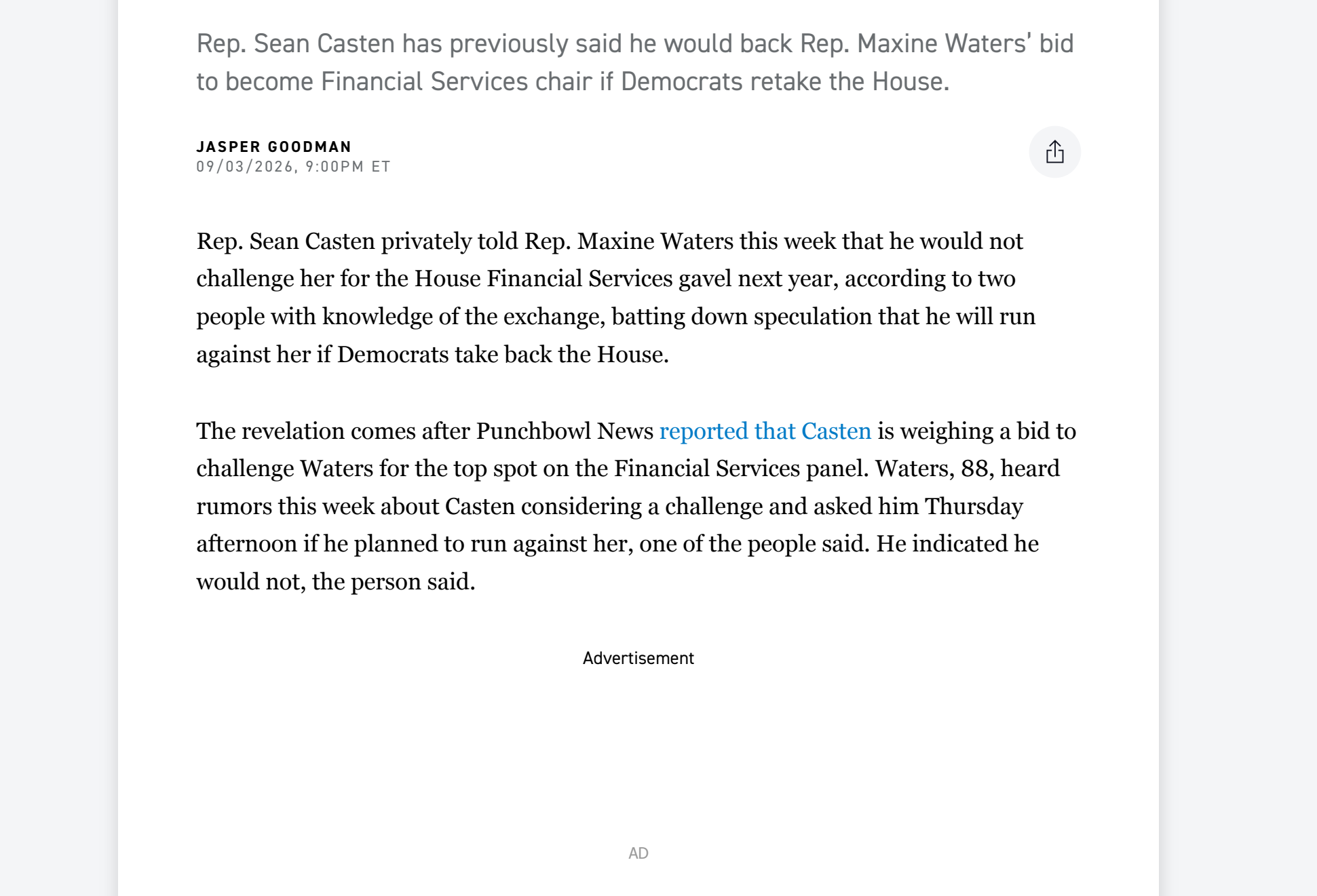

SEP 2026

Casten tells Waters he won't challenge her for Financial Services gavel — but won't rule it out publicly

Rep. Sean Casten has previously said he would back Rep. Maxine Waters' bid to become Financial Services chair if Democrats retake the House.

JASPER GOODMAN
09/03/2026, 9:00PM ET

Rep. Sean Casten privately told Rep. Maxine Waters this week that he would not challenge her for the House Financial Services gavel next year, according to two people with knowledge of the exchange, batting down speculation that he will run against her if Democrats take back the House.

The revelation comes after Punchbowl News reported that Casten is weighing a bid to challenge Waters for the top spot on the Financial Services panel. Waters, 88, heard rumors this week about Casten considering a challenge and asked him Thursday afternoon if he planned to run against her, one of the people said. He indicated he would not, the person said.

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Yet, Casten, 54, is not publicly denying that he is considering a bid. The Illinois Democrat said in a statement Thursday that he has "great respect for Ranking Member Waters, who has made the Financial Services Committee my home in Congress."

"My focus is on working to ensure we take back the majority," he said.

Casten, who currently serves as the vice ranking member of House Financial Services, has privately expressed interest in succeeding Waters as Financial Services chair, according to two people with knowledge of his thinking. But POLITICO cannot independently confirm that he is currently considering running against Waters.

A spokesperson for Waters did not immediately respond to a request for comment about the matter.

Casten has previously said he backs Waters. In an interview on Nov. 21, 2025, he told POLITICO: "I think she does a great job and she's got my support as long as she wants to stay in that seat."

"She brings the fire," he said at the time. "I think in this moment you want people who are fighters."

Waters would be the oldest House Financial Services chair ever — a concern for some Democrats who want fresh blood in the seat. Asked about her age last November, Casten said he didn't have any concerns about Waters' abilities.

"I am a firm believer that when people are visibly past their time, it's time to sort of have some hard conversations," he said. "That's a mental issue, not an age issue. And I don't have any concern that she's mentally up for the job."

House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries, who is in line to become speaker if Democrats retake the House, has also signaled support for Waters. In a statement to POLITICO in March, Jeffries said that Waters "has led the Financial Services Committee with vision, intellect, passion and skill."

"It's my expectation that such iconic leadership will continue in the 120th Congress," he said at the time.

Lead Art: Rep. Sean Casten said in a statement Thursday that he has "great respect for Ranking Member Waters, who has made the Financial Services Committee my home in Congress." | Cliff Owen/AP

SEP 2026

Virginia Democrat says FBI monitored his calls in corruption probe

Suhas Subramanyam said FBI and DOJ informed him his calls were monitored as part of case involving a Virginia state senator.

CHEYANNE M. DANIELS
09/03/2026, 6:11PM ET

Virginia Democrat Rep. Suhas Subramanyam says federal authorities monitored phone conversations he had with a state senator as part of a corruption investigation.

Subramanyam, who previously served as a state lawmaker in Virginia, said in a statement Thursday that the FBI and Department of Justice informed him that they monitored conversations he had with state Sen. L. Louise Lucas as part of their investigation of her.

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The first-term member of Congress noted what he called the "extremely suspicious" timing of the wiretap between March and May, when Virginia Democrats were at the peak of campaigning for a referendum to enable mid-decade redistricting in the state.

"This should concern anyone who believes in a real Department of Justice that serves the American people and not a singular president," he said.

In May, the FBI raided the office of Lucas and a retail cannabis business she co-owns as part of the investigation. No charges have been filed and the scope of any investigation remains unknown.

The Justice Department did not immediately respond to a request for comment on Subramanyam's statement.

Lead Art: Rep. Suhas Subramanyam (D-Va.) at a news conference on Capitol Hill. | Mariam Zuhaib/AP

SEP 2026

Max Miller **gets NRCC's help** on the airwaves

The Ohio Republican facing allegations of domestic abuse is not on a list of national GOP priority candidates.

By **MIA MCCARTHY** and **RILEY ROGERSON**
09/03/2026, 4:50PM ET
UPDATED: 09/03/2026, 7:19PM ET

House Republicans' national campaign arm is joining with embattled GOP Rep. Max Miller to buy TV airtime as allegations of domestic abuse against him put the previously safe north Ohio seat into play.

The NRCC is planning a joint three-week ad buy with Miller's campaign starting Sept. 7 and totaling more than $450,000. Miller, who represents parts of the Cleveland suburbs, is not among the NRCC's "Patriots" — the most vulnerable members who typically get the bulk of its spending.

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"Democrat Brian Poindexter backs a radical far-left agenda that's completely out of touch with northeast Ohio," NRCC spokesperson Zach Bannon said in a statement. "Ohioans have a clear choice: Max Miller will vote to stop socialist policies, and Bernie-bro Brian Poindexter will make them a reality."

Miller said in a statement that he is grateful to Rep. Richard Hudson (R-N.C.), the NRCC chair, for his "faith in my ability to win this race and the support the NRCC is supplying."

"Republicans know that this race is bigger than me, it's about ensuring we maintain this majority," he said.

Miller is facing allegations of abuse from his ex-wife Emily Moreno, the daughter of Ohio Sen. Bernie Moreno. Both of Ohio's GOP senators have called on Miller to resign over the allegations, which Miller denies.

A DCCC spokesperson, Riya Vashi, called the joint ad buy "a new low" for national Republicans.

"National Republicans are proudly bankrolling an alleged abuser with a lengthy history of damning accusations from multiple women," she said. "Every House Republican who gives a dime to the NRCC owns this shameful choice."

The ad buy comes after Miller's Democratic challenger Brian Poindexter released his first ad of the general election earlier this week, largely focused on his own family, which is running as part of a six-figure buy on digital, cable and broadcast television.

Amid calls to drop his reelection bid last month, Miller remained defiant and refused to exit the race ahead of the deadline to pick another GOP candidate, and Republicans including members of President Donald Trump's political circle have rallied around him since it became clear he would remain on the ballot.

Speaker Mike Johnson earlier this week said that he supports Miller's reelection, though he later said he is not planning to campaign with Miller before the election.

Andrew Howard contributed to this report.

Lead Art: Rep. Max Miller arrives for a vote at the U.S. Capitol on Sept. 1, 2026. | Francis Chung/POLITICO

SEP 2026

Stauber will run for top Republican on House Natural Resources, while Westerman ponders next move

Westerman is term-limited but could seek a waiver to serve another two years.

KELSEY BRUGGER
09/03/2026, 3:06PM ET

Rep. Pete Stauber of Minnesota is making a run for the top Republican spot on the House Natural Resources Committee in the next Congress — teeing up a potential battle with the current chair, Bruce Westerman, who isn't ruling out asking for a waiver to serve another term.

"Congressman Stauber is running to serve as chair/ranking member of Natural Resources, and he is speaking to members of our Conference, including steering members," his spokesperson said in an email Thursday.

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The GOP Steering Committee, composed of party leaders and members of the conference representing different geographic regions, will meet after the midterms to make assignments to the House's standing committees — and vote on recommendations for who should be the senior Republican on those committees.

Stauber has sat on Natural Resources since 2020 and currently chairs the Energy and Mineral Resources Subcommittee. He has long been active on energy and environmental issues and led the successful effort to overturn a Biden-era ban on mining near the Boundary Waters wilderness in his district.

His public interest in leading his party on the panel could create an uncomfortable showdown with Westerman. The Arkansas Republican is finishing up his third term as the top Republican on Natural Resources and so must step aside at the end of this year, per House GOP term limit rules. But Westerman also could seek a waiver from the steering committee to serve a fourth term, and in an interview Thursday, he was noncommittal on his plans.

"We'll figure all that out after the election," Westerman said, adding he was at this time "more focused on winning the majority."

"It's premature for me to be talking about a waiver right now," he added — but, when asked whether that meant he would not ask for one, he replied, "I didn't say that."

Westerman also dismissed the idea that a decision to move ahead with a waiver request would forecast a messy fight with Stauber.

"Pete and me battling? No … Pete and I have always been friends, and I'm just not focused on that," he said.

Stauber's spokesperson said the lawmaker would pursue the committee leadership position regardless of Westerman's decision.

Westerman is one of multiple Republican chairs who are term-limited next year and considering asking for an exemption, while risking some intraparty conflicts along the way.

House Agriculture Chair GT Thompson (R-Pa.) has already submitted a waiver request and circulated it with colleagues, including those on steering, according to a document obtained by POLITICO. It comes as Rep. Austin Scott (R-Ga.), who is next in line to become chair or ranking member of the committee, has privately approached GOP leaders about succeeding Thompson, according to a person granted anonymity to discuss private discussions.

Rep. Mike Rogers of Arkansas, the chair of House Armed Services, also plans to seek a waiver to serve as the top Republican on the panel in the next Congress. Republican Reps. Ronny Jackson of Texas, Rob Wittman of Virginia and Trent Kelly of Mississippi have said they are interested in the position as well.

CORRECTION: An earlier version of this story misstated the name of the forest in Rep. Pete Stauber's district.

Lead Art: Rep. Pete Stauber (R-Minn.) departs a vote at the U.S. Capitol on July 23, 2026. | Francis Chung/POLITICO

SEP 2026

2 House Democrats **face off for leadership** slot

Reps. Sara Jacobs and Lauren Underwood are seeking to become caucus vice chair.

RILEY ROGERSON
09/03/2026, 3:00PM ET

A fierce internal battle is developing among House Democrats.

Reps. Sara Jacobs of California and Lauren Underwood of Illinois are expected to seek the caucus vice chair post. The job is currently held by Rep. Ted Lieu of California, who is term limited regardless of the election's outcome and expected to become caucus chair if Democrats take the majority. In that scenario, Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries is poised to become speaker and other members of the party leadership would step one rung up the ladder, meaning the vice chair slot could be the only obvious vacancy in the House Democratic hierarchy.

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Jacobs sent a Dear Colleague letter Monday officially declaring her run, while a person familiar with Underwood's thinking who was granted anonymity to discuss her plans said she is "definitely running" but is "exclusively focused on winning back the House" for the time being.

The two candidates already hold several lower-level leadership positions. Jacobs is the parliamentarian of House Democrats' Steering and Policy Committee and is a regional vice chair of the Democratic Congressional Campaign Committee. Underwood is a co-chair of House Democrats' messaging arm, the Democratic Policy and Communications Committee. She is also a co-chair of the DCCC's Red to Blue program.

Rep. Lori Trahan of Massachusetts had also been floating a run to colleagues but announced Wednesday that she is no longer pursuing the role. Some House Democrats have bristled at Trahan's attempt to broker a bipartisan deal to regulate artificial intelligence.

"Rep. Trahan is grateful to the many colleagues who've encouraged her to run for Vice Chair," spokesperson Francis Grubar said in a statement. "She has decided not to seek the position, and will keep her focus on the issues she's been working diligently to address, including confronting the real risks of frontier AI."

"She'll keep doing everything in her power to elect Democrats, retake the House, and make Hakeem Jeffries the next Speaker," he added.

Correction: An earlier version of this story said the vice chair role would only be open if Democrats take the majority. The role will be vacant next term because Lieu is term limited.

Lead Art: Rep. Sara Jacobs (D-Calif.) attends a House Democratic Caucus meeting on Capitol Hill Nov. 12, 2025. | Francis Chung/POLITICO

SEP 2026

Hakeem Jeffries declines to detail **consequences for rogue Democrats,** cites 'forward-looking' conversation

Party leaders chided Reps. Jared Golden and Marie Gluesenkamp Perez for a "breach of trust" warranting a "serious response."

RILEY ROGERSON
09/03/2026, 12:26PM ET

House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries declined Thursday to outline any specific consequences for two rogue members who joined Republicans on a key procedural vote earlier this week despite a swell of Democrats calling for swift punishment.

Jeffries said at a news conference that he spoke to one of the defectors, Rep. Marie Gluesenkamp Perez of Washington, about her vote that advanced a slate of GOP-led bills. She did not inform party leaders ahead of time.

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Jeffries described their discussion as "productive" and "forward-looking" and said it

Jeffries described their discussion as “productive” and “forward-looking” and said it addressed how they can move “in a direction that allows the team to continue to communicate with each other in a consistent way, where we can arrive at shared priorities and advance the interests of the American people.”

Jeffries and other Democratic leaders issued a blistering statement after the Tuesday note accusing Gluesenkamp Perez and Rep. Jared Golden of Maine of a “breach of trust” warranted a “serious response.”

While Golden is retiring, Gluesenkamp Perez is seeking reelection in a red-tinged district. Some members have suggested she should lose her spot on the coveted Appropriations Committee over the vote.

Asked about punishments, Jeffries instead cited an ongoing “family discussion about how we all move forward together.”

“All parties involved understand that we’ve got to make sure that we’re communicating aggressively with each other at all times,” he later added.

Jeffries tapped an internal panel in charge of caucus rules to consider sanctions and new requirements to bar House Democrats from joining Republicans on key procedural votes. That panel met Wednesday and made no immediate action.

“We had a meeting. We listened to members yesterday,” Rep. Pete Aguilar of California, the Democratic Caucus chair, said in a Thursday interview when asked what the promised “serious response” would be. “We’ll continue to do that. That’s kind of how we operate.”

Lead Art: House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries arrives for a news conference on Capitol Hill on Sept. 3, 2026. | Francis Chung/POLITICO

SEP 2026

Speaker Mike Johnson’s decision to cut the House schedule short won’t affect one late-September congressional spectacle: Multiple members said Thursday that the Congressional Women’s Softball Game will proceed as planned on Sept. 23.

The event, which pits a team of women members against an all-media team, is a fundraiser for the benefit Young Survival Coalition, a group supporting young women diagnosed with breast cancer.

“It’s the only day we can play,” said Rep. Debbie Wasserman Schultz (D-Fla.), a captain of the member team. “We’re playing in Audi Field, and yeah, members are coming back.”

By **RILEY ROGERSON** and **MIA MCCARTHY**
09/03/2026, 10:22AM ET

SEP 2026

Leon Black defies House Oversight Committee, sues Congress amid Epstein investigation

Committee leaders could pursue contempt proceedings against the billionaire investor.

CHRIS MARQUETTE
09/03/2026, 10:02AM ET
UPDATED: 09/03/2026, 11:30AM ET

Lead Art: Leon Black retrieves his belongings after undergoing security screening as he arrives for a closed interview with the House Oversight Committee regarding the investigation into convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein on Capitol Hill on June 26, 2026. | Francis Chung/POLITICO

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SEP 2026

House Republicans set to **cut pre-election session short**

Leaders are canceling two weeks of scheduled late-September business.

By **MEREDITH LEE HILL**, **MIA MCCARTHY** and **RILEY ROGERSON**
09/03/2026, 9:53AM ET
UPDATED: 09/03/2026, 11:38AM ET

Republican leaders announced Thursday that the final two weeks of the pre-election House session are canceled, severely curtailing what had been a full legislative calendar for September.

That means members are set to depart Washington no later than Sept. 17 and not return until mid-November. The House will reconvene for one additional week of business after next week’s Labor Day break.

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Leaders would recall House members for those canceled weeks if the Senate moves forward with a party-line budget reconciliation package in the meantime, GOP leaders indicated, though that is not anticipated.

The decision comes as candidates agitate to get back on the campaign trail and as GOP leaders continue to struggle to maintain control of the House floor. Earlier this week, a procedural measure setting up votes on several Republican bills was poised to fail until two Democrats voted in favor, rescuing Speaker Mike Johnson‘s agenda for the week.

Johnson has claimed the GOP-led House has been unusually productive this Congress despite the floor challenges and his decision to keep the chamber out of session for nearly two months last year during a government shutdown.

Speaking to reporters Thursday, he cited a lack of action in the Senate as a reason he was comfortable curtailing the pre-election calendar, as well as pre-midterm political pressures.

“I’ll point out that there’s almost 600 pieces of that landmark legislation that are still sitting over in the other chamber in the Senate, and so we need to get more and more of that done,” he said. “Of course, we’re in the middle of a critical midterm election. Many [members] want and need to be in their districts, working with their constituents, and running their campaigns. And so we’re trying to balance all those interests and needs right now.”

Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries cast the curtailed schedule as proof of the GOP’s “failure.”

“House Republicans have nothing to do as it relates to advancing the health, the safety, and the economic well-being of the American people,” he said. “These aren’t commonsense Republicans. These are individuals who have unleashed chaos, confusion and corruption on the American people, and so it should come as no surprise that Republicans have canceled votes.”

Lead Art: House Speaker Mike Johnson (R-La.) emerges from a House Republican Conference meeting at the U.S. Capitol on Sept. 1, 2026. | Francis Chung/POLITICO

SEP 2026

Sanders, Casar call for ban on artificial superintelligence

The duo is preparing legislation to pause development of all cutting-edge AI until an agency is in place to monitor for risks.

By **OWEN DAHLKAMP** and **KELSEY BRUGGER**
09/03/2026, 9:25AM ET

Sen. Bernie Sanders (I-Vt.) and Rep. Greg Casar (D-Texas) are calling for a ban on artificial superintelligence and a broader pause on the development of advanced models following a string of AI-powered cyberattacks.

The pair are preparing to introduce a bill that would ban the development and deployment of superintelligence and pause development of cutting-edge AI models until an agency is created to monitor their capabilities and identify potential risks. Sanders and Casar, the chair of the Congressional Progressive Caucus, have positioned themselves as leading voices on the left warning of the potential for mass job loss and economic disruption while Big Tech flourishes.

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“Nearly every day, there is a frightening new story about how Big Tech companies are losing control of the technology they are developing, with potentially cataclysmic results,” Sanders said in a statement. “It is irresponsible for society to allow them to move forward and make these products even more advanced.”

Casar said that superintelligence, a type of AI with cognitive capabilities that far surpass humans, “could risk the security, freedom, and lives of Americans.”

“Despite its potential deadly consequences, cutting edge AI technology is less regulated than the average food truck,” he said. “That must change.”

Casar in an interview earlier this year said Democrats were “in the wilderness” when it comes to AI issues and called for the party to be “AI populists” who “stand with working people who know in their gut that AI right now is just going to make a few billionaires into trillionaires while making millions of Americans poorer, less safe and less free.”

Sanders was the first member of Congress to call for a moratorium on the construction of data centers that power AI.

Lawmakers have failed to make any real progress on AI legislation this Congress as members in both parties have yet to coalesce around clear positions on safety reviews, regulations and data center construction. There’s little hope a comprehensive package will come together by the end of the year.

Lead Art: Sen. Bernie Sanders (I-Vt.) speaks during a rally ahead of New York’s primary election, Thursday, June 18, 2026, in the Brooklyn borough of New York. | Ryan Murphy/AP

SEP 2026

Capitol agenda: Dems test **new data center** attack

“A year ago, Republicans were bragging about giving tax breaks to Big Tech in order to build data centers,” Rep. Jim McGovern said.

CALEN RAZOR
09/03/2026, 8:00AM ET

Democrats are trying to pin voter uproar over data centers on Republicans by spotlighting a tax provision buried in the GOP’s signature megabill last year.

“A year ago, Republicans were bragging about giving tax breaks to Big Tech in order to build data centers,” Rep. Jim McGovern said. “With November on the horizon, some House Republicans are acting as if they did not turbocharge the data center buildout.”

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Democrats are hoping their messaging not only drives a wedge in the deepening Republican divide over data centers, but also undercuts GOP attempts to trumpet their One Big Beautiful Bill Act as a crowning legislative achievement ahead of the midterms.

The fresh line of attack zeroes in on the “Opportunity Zone” tax credit program — an initiative designed to boost growth in areas deemed underdeveloped, which, at one point after the megabill’s passage, Republicans had touted as a way to spur the construction of data centers.

President Donald Trump’s Monday post calling for Americans to “let Data Reign” gave Democrats their latest opening to strike a contrast, as Republicans struggle to bridge Trump’s unwavering support with their own constituents’ concerns.

Poll after poll shows growing frustrations with the centers throughout the country, including in key House and Senate races necessary for the GOP to hold onto its majorities.

Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries in a news conference this week accused House Republicans of voting to “unleash data centers on the American people in an unfettered fashion.”

Rep. David Valadao of California, for example, has found himself under scrutiny for his vote on the 2025 megabill, but pushed back on Democrats’ strategy.

“I mean, obviously there are local concerns that need to be addressed,” Valadao said in an interview, but added of Democrats’ attacks that, “trying to use something that a lot of people would argue is important for national security or national security interests as a political weapon sounds pretty irresponsible.”

House Ways and Means Chair Jason Smith, who oversaw the expansion of the tax credits in the law, called Democrats’ narrative a “huge stretch.”

“Opportunity Zones control, like, everything — from child daycare centers to manufacturers. Can data centers be used in them? Yes. But so can everything else,” Smith said.

An analysis from the National Community Reinvestment Coalition published this month figures 14 percent of data centers are in Opportunity Zones, while 17 percent of those in the works are similarly situated.

Some Republicans, nonetheless, have been pressing Speaker Mike Johnson on whether leadership has plans to put any data center-related legislation on the floor in the next month, but have received no commitments.

What else we’re watching:

— **TRUMP PROMISES MIDTERM HELP:** Trump on Wednesday told a group of embattled Republicans he’s coming to help. Trump told a group of GOP lawmakers at the White House he’ll campaign for about 35 of them in the final month ahead of the midterms. “We’re going to take that final 30 days, you don’t want to go too much before that because people forget,” the president said, adding that he will rely on Johnson to supply names where the Republican is tied, losing or winning by a small margin.

— **HOUSE DEMS WATCH JEFFRIES ON ROGUE MEMBERS:** Rank-and-file House Democrats are watching closely to see if Jeffries will follow through on reining in rogue members who helped bail Republicans out of a nearly failed agenda this week. Many are hoping their leaders send a message to Reps. Marie Gluesenkamp Perez and Jared Golden that such tactics won’t be tolerated in a future majority. Some have privately suggested kicking Gluesenkamp Perez off of her role on Appropriations, while others have cautioned against overpolicing.

Kelsey Brugger, Brian Faler, Alex Gangitano, Riley Rogerson and Mia McCarthy contributed to this report.

Lead Art: House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries calls on a reporter during a press conference at the U.S. Capitol on June 23, 2026. | Francis Chung/POLITICO

SEP 2026

Third Way rolls out **“new economic bargain” platform** for Dems

The platform consists of what the group calls 20 “ambitious and ruthlessly pragmatic” ideas, shared first with POLITICO, targeting working-class voters.

ADAM WREN
09/03/2026, 5:55AM ET

The Democratic centrist group Third Way is launching a “new economic bargain” platform as part of its ongoing effort to steer the party toward a more coherent and big-tent vision heading into 2028.

The platform consists of what it calls 20 “ambitious and ruthlessly pragmatic” ideas, shared first with POLITICO, targeting working-class voters. The ideas include a health care Bill of Rights, government-backed car loans to lower the cost of car ownership and forcing AI companies to pay for their own expansion without passing it on to consumers.

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“Now that the primaries are over, the big question for Democrats is: What are you going to run on in the general election in ’26? What are you going to legislate on in ’27? And what are you going to promise to do and deliver if you become president?” Jon Cowan, Third Way’s president, said in an interview. “And so we see this now as the pivot moment away from the primaries and toward the policy debate in the party.”

Cowan said the policy ideas provide an affirmative vision for the party, instead of just being anti-Trump, saying the agenda is aimed at “Democrats who want to be able to beat MAGA, because here’s the key thing: you can’t beat something with nothing.”

Earlier this year, the influential think tank launched a $50 million effort seeking to make sure a “combative centrist” emerges as the party’s 2028 presidential nominee.

Now, Third Way has elevated a dedicated staffer — Sasha Galbreath, a longtime House policy adviser — to establish connections between the group and staffers for potential 2028 presidential and vice presidential candidates. The group is already in conversation with at least 16 potential candidates and their staff, according to Cowan.

“The ideas primary is really only just beginning now,” Cowan said. “I think the pivot into September and the end of the primaries is actually when the real ideas primary to determine the future of the Democratic Party begins.”

Lead Art: At a gathering of top consultants and strategists, center-left Democrats pitched how to talk about foreign policy in 2028. | Elena Schneider/POLITICO

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